

CIVITAS Public: Building a European Digital Agora — A Call to Action

Concept Paper for a Trustworthy European Civic Publication and Debate
Platform

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A Call to Action

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Abstract

Europe’s democratic public sphere faces a structural deficit: civic discourse is overwhelmingly mediated by commercially governed platforms whose incentives — advertising, behavioural capture, emotional amplification — are misaligned with democratic quality and public trust. At the same time, no credible European-scale digital infrastructure exists that combines open civic publication, structured debate, transparent polling, and accountable participation under democratic governance.

This paper proposes **CIVITAS Public** as a concrete, actionable first step towards filling this gap. CIVITAS Public is conceived as a non-commercial, open-source, multilingual platform for verified publication, structured debate, trend observation, civic questions, and modular participatory expansion — governed by transparent rules, independent oversight, and rule-of-law safeguards. Situated within the broader ERDA (European Resilience and Democratic Architecture) framework, CIVITAS Public is designed to be both immediately useful and institutionally extensible.

The paper presents the problem analysis, normative foundation, operational model, role and publication architecture, governance framework, technical design, phased roadmap, risk assessment, and strategic value proposition. It concludes with a call to action directed at civic-technology communities, European institutions, media organisations, academic networks, and civil society to collaborate in launching CIVITAS Public as the first building block of Europe’s democratic digital future.

Keywords: CIVITAS, ERDA, digital democracy, European public sphere, civic technology, democratic infrastructure, public debate, verification, open source, digital agora

Zusammenfassung

Europas demokratische Öffentlichkeit steht vor einem strukturellen Defizit: Öffentlicher Diskurs wird überwiegend auf kommerziellen Plattformen geführt, deren Anreizstrukturen — Werbung, Verhaltensfassung, emotionale Verstärkung — mit demokratischer Qualität und öffentlichem Vertrauen unvereinbar sind. Zugleich fehlt eine glaubwürdige europäische digitale Infrastruktur, die offene Publikation, strukturierte Debatte, transparente Meinungserhebung und verantwortungsvolle Partizipation unter demokratischer Kontrolle vereint.

Dieses Papier schlägt **CIVITAS Public** als konkreten, umsetzbaren ersten Schritt vor, um diese Lücke zu schließen. CIVITAS Public ist als nicht-kommerzielle, quelloffene, mehrsprachige Plattform für verifizierte Publikation, strukturierte Debatte, Trendbeobachtung, Bürgerfragen und modulare partizipative Erweiterung konzipiert — getragen von transparenten Regeln, unabhängiger Aufsicht und rechtsstaatlichen Garantien. Eingebettet in den ERDA-Rahmen (European Resilience and Democratic Architecture - europäische Resilienz und demokratische Architektur) soll CIVITAS Public sowohl unmittelbar nützlich als auch institutionell ausbaufähig sein.

Das Papier legt Problemanalyse, normative Grundlage, Betriebsmodell, Rollen- und Publikationsarchitektur, Governance-Rahmen, technisches Design, Stufenplan, Risikobewertung und strategischen Mehrwert dar. Es schließt mit einem Aufruf an Civic-Tech-Gemeinschaften, europäische Institutionen, Medienorganisationen, Wissenschaftsnetzwerke und Zivilgesellschaft, CIVITAS Public als ersten Baustein der digitalen demokratischen Zukunft Europas gemeinsam aufzubauen.

Schlüsselwörter: CIVITAS, ERDA, digitale Demokratie, europäische Öffentlichkeit, Civic Tech, demokratische Infrastruktur, öffentliche Debatte, Verifikation, Open Source, digitale Agora

1. Introduction: Why Europe Needs a Digital Agora Now

Europe possesses one of the world’s richest democratic traditions. Yet its digital public sphere — the space where citizens inform themselves, debate, organise, and hold institutions accountable — is structurally dependent on platforms governed from outside Europe, optimised for commercial extraction rather than democratic exchange.

This is not merely a communication problem. It is a **democratic infrastructure gap**.

The consequences are visible across the continent: declining trust in public institutions [1], increasing political polarisation amplified by algorithmic incentives [2], vulnerability to coordinated disinformation campaigns [3], and a growing sense among citizens that their voices do not meaningfully reach political decision-making. The European Commission’s own Digital Services Act acknowledges the systemic risks of very large online platforms, yet regulation alone cannot create what is missing: a **positive digital public infrastructure** built for democratic purposes.

CIVITAS Public is proposed as a realistic, concrete, and immediately actionable response. Named after the Latin concept of civic community, CIVITAS Public is not a utopian vision for a distant future — it is a practical first layer of a European digital agora that can be built, tested, and expanded starting now.

This paper makes the case for why CIVITAS Public is needed, what it should look like, and how it can be started. It is an explicit invitation to act.

2. Problem Analysis

2.1 Commercial Platform Dominance

A substantial share of European civic discourse now occurs on platforms whose core business model depends on attention maximisation, behavioural tracking, and advertising revenue [4]. Democratic quality — fairness, accuracy, accountability, deliberative depth — is not a design objective of these systems. Where it occurs, it is incidental rather than structural.

2.2 Erosion of Epistemic Trust

Citizens increasingly struggle to distinguish well-grounded analysis from ideological messaging, coordinated manipulation from organic opinion, and institutional communication from superficial content marketing. The result is not healthy scepticism but systemic epistemic uncertainty — a condition in which citizens lack reliable heuristics to navigate public information [5].

2.3 Institutional Discontinuity

Thoughtful civic contributions — policy analyses, citizen proposals, expert assessments — frequently disappear into algorithmically curated feeds. There is no persistent, structured, publicly accessible space where civic knowledge accumulates, develops continuity, and becomes institutionally actionable.

2.4 European Discourse Fragmentation

Despite shared institutional frameworks, European public debate remains largely confined within national and linguistic boundaries. Cross-border deliberation happens primarily among elites, while the broader European public lacks accessible, multilingual spaces for joint civic engagement.

2.5 The Missing Middle

Between unstructured social media and closed institutional communication, there exists a critically underbuilt space: one that is **open enough to sustain genuine public life** yet **structured enough to uphold trust, accountability, and democratic usefulness**. CIVITAS Public is designed to occupy precisely this space.

2.6 Research Questions and Success Indicators

To move from aspiration to evidence, CIVITAS Public adopts four guiding research questions:

1. **Discourse quality:** Can a moderated, verified civic platform sustain higher-quality public discourse — measured by argument diversity, source density, and deliberative depth — than equivalent discussions on unmoderated commercial platforms?
2. **Participation breadth:** Does the platform attract and retain a demographically representative cross-section of European citizens, or does it reproduce existing participation gaps (age, geography, education, digital literacy)?
3. **Trust formation:** Does structured verification and transparent moderation increase civic trust in platform-mediated information, compared to baseline trust levels in social-media-sourced information?
4. **Institutional uptake:** To what extent do democratic institutions, media organisations, and civil society actors integrate CIVITAS Public outputs into their decision-making, reporting, or advocacy?

These questions will be operationalised through the following **key performance indicators (KPIs)**:

KPI	Measurement Method	Target (Phase 1)	Target (Phase 2)
Monthly active users	Platform analytics	5,000	50,000
Verified author registrations	Identity system logs	200	2,000
Publication volume (articles + briefs)	Content database	500/year	3,000/year
Average review level per publication	Review metadata	≥ Level A (100%)	≥ Level B (60%)
User trust score (survey)	Biannual user survey	Baseline + 10%	Baseline + 25%
Cross-border readership share	Analytics by country	≥ 3 EU countries	≥ 10 EU countries
Institutional citation/uptake	External monitoring	5 references	50 references

Evaluation will follow a **pre-registered mixed-methods design**: quantitative platform analytics complemented by qualitative user interviews, expert focus groups, and periodic comparison studies against commercial platform discourse samples. Results will be published as open-access evaluation reports.

3. The CIVITAS Vision within the ERDA Framework

CIVITAS is a core component of the ERDA (European Resilience and Democratic Architecture) framework [6], which proposes a comprehensive renewal of Europe’s strategic, ethical, and

democratic foundations. Within ERDA, CIVITAS serves as the **digital democracy infrastructure** — the platform through which citizens participate, deliberate, and exercise democratic agency in the digital age.

The full CIVITAS vision encompasses:

- a verified debate space with AI-assisted and human moderation,
- citizens’ petitions with digital threshold mechanisms,
- interfaces to elections, eVoting, and EU consultations,
- political information modules including legislative trackers and voting records,
- civic-technology tools for shaping public initiatives,
- educational pathways for digital democratic literacy.

CIVITAS Public represents the **first operational layer** of this vision: publicly visible, immediately useful, and designed to demonstrate that a European digital agora is not only desirable but feasible.

3.1 Existing Civic Platforms and Lessons Learned

CIVITAS Public does not emerge in a vacuum. Several European civic-technology platforms have demonstrated that participatory digital infrastructure is both technically feasible and politically impactful. Understanding their strengths and limitations is essential for informed design.

Platform	Origin	Licence	Focus	Governance	Multilingual	Key Lesson for CIVITAS
Decidim [11]	Barcelona, ES	AGPL-3.0	Participatory processes, budgets, consultations	Municipal / community-driven	Yes (40+ languages)	Modular architecture enables diverse civic use cases; governance must scale beyond municipal origin
Consul	Madrid, ES	AGPL-3.0	Citizen proposals, debates, participatory budgets	City government-led	Yes (30+ languages)	Strong uptake (100+ cities) but limited cross-border federation; central governance can limit independence

Platform	Origin	Licence	Focus	Governance	Multilingual	Key Lesson for CIVITAS
Your Priorities	Reykjavík, IS	BSD	Idea generation, prioritisation	Citizens Foundation (NGO)	Partial	AI-assisted idea clustering works at scale; needs stronger verification layer
OpenStad	Netherlands	Open source	Neighbourhood participation, budgets	Municipal toolkit	Dutch-focused	Effective local engagement but not designed for transnational civic discourse
Participa	Portugal	Proprietary	National consultations	Government-operated	Portuguese	Demonstrates institutional adoption but raises independence concerns when government-run

Key differentiators of CIVITAS Public:

- **Publication-first architecture:** Existing platforms focus on proposals, votes, or budgets. CIVITAS prioritises structured, accountable *publication and debate* — closer to a democratic press infrastructure than a voting tool.
- **Verification and review layers:** No existing platform combines identity verification with a three-level editorial review system.
- **European-scale multilingual design:** While Decidim supports many languages, no platform is designed from the ground up for transnational European civic discourse with built-in translation infrastructure.
- **Independence by design:** CIVITAS is conceived as a foundation-governed, non-governmental platform — neither municipal nor state-operated — with explicit anti-capture safeguards.
- **Extensibility toward democratic integration:** The roadmap explicitly includes petition connectors, parliamentary interfaces, and federation — features absent from current platforms.

CIVITAS Public draws on the demonstrated successes of these platforms while addressing their structural gaps: limited verification, weak cross-border design, absence of structured publication formats, and insufficient independence mechanisms [12].

4. Guiding Principles

CIVITAS Public is built on four foundational principles:

1. **Open Readability** — All published content is freely accessible to every person, without registration barriers or paywalls.
2. **Trustworthy Publication** — Contributors publish under verified identities with transparent accountability. Trust is structural, not assumed.
3. **Structured Democratic Debate** — Exchange follows deliberative formats designed for clarity, mutual understanding, and productive disagreement — not the engagement-maximising dynamics of commercial platforms.
4. **Extensible Architecture** — The platform is designed for modular growth, enabling future integration of petitions, consultations, educational interfaces, parliamentary connectors, and federation with other democratic platforms.

5. Operational Model

The operational purpose of CIVITAS Public is concise:

Readable for all. Trustworthy through verification. Valuable through accountability.

This translates into four immediate operational objectives:

5.1 Trustworthy Publication. Contributions appear as accountable publications with clear authorship, role attribution, source logic, revision history, and stable identifiers — not as anonymous fragments in opaque feeds.

5.2 Structured Public Orientation. Instead of endless reaction chains, the platform privileges thematic rooms, dossiers, question formats, debate structures, and evolving issue maps that enable citizens to orient themselves on complex topics.

5.3 European Intelligibility. The system is multilingual, transnationally legible, and capable of connecting national public conversations without erasing their contextual specificity.

5.4 Institutional Extensibility. The initial architecture supports later addition of petitions, consultations, educational interfaces, local civic rooms, and parliamentary connectors without requiring a fundamental platform redesign.

6. Role Architecture

Combining openness with quality requires a layered role structure:

Role	Access Level	Requirements
Reader	Full read access to all public content	None
Registered Participant	Polls, topic following, questions, reactions	Registration
Verified Author	Publication under accountable profile	Identity verification
Certified Publisher	Publication with additional quality signals	Professional, institutional, or civic qualification

Certified Publisher categories may include: journalistic review status, research or expert review status, civic or municipal practice status, civil society legitimacy, youth representation status, invited guest contribution status, and civic-technology expertise status.

This model ensures that the platform remains **universally accessible for reading** while ensuring that **publication carries responsibility and interpretive clarity**.

7. Publication Architecture

7.1 Publication Formats

CIVITAS Public launches with six clearly defined formats:

1. **Article** — structured publication with sources, author profile, topic assignment, and version history.
2. **Brief** — shorter, highly focused analytical or explanatory piece.
3. **Dossier** — thematic collection of developments, perspectives, sources, and issue trajectories.
4. **Citizen Question** — public civic question with qualified response from verified experts or editors.
5. **Debate Format** — structured multi-perspective exchange with moderated process.
6. **Trend Report** — interpreted summary of issue dynamics and platform resonance.

7.2 Persistent Identification

Every publication receives a stable **CIVITAS-ID** comprising: unique identifier, publication date, version number, author profile, thematic room, stable URL, and recommended citation string.

Example: CIVITAS-PUBLIC-2026-ARTICLE-00017-v1

DOI registration may be introduced for selected archival publications in later phases.

7.3 Version Transparency

Every publication includes visible revision history, ensuring that updates, corrections, and expansions remain publicly intelligible and traceable.

8. Review and Quality Assurance

A three-level review model balances rigour with practicality:

Level A — Basic Review (mandatory for all publications): identity or role verification, formal compliance, source and format check, rule conformity, content type labelling.

Level B — Editorial Review (for substantial pieces): plausibility review, structure and clarity assessment, source logic evaluation, format refinement.

Level C — Expert Review (for major analytical or methodological texts): optional expert assessment, documented review notes, possible publication of review status.

Each published item visibly displays its format, review status, correction history, and responsible contributor or editorial entity.

9. Polling, Trends, and Public Resonance

9.1 Poll Types

Type	Purpose	Scope
Community Poll	Quick platform-internal mood indicator	All registered participants
Structured Poll	Carefully framed issue-specific survey	Targeted participant groups
Expert Snapshot	Qualified perspective from professional or civic group	Certified publishers
Youth Pulse	Targeted youth participation format	Young CIVITAS participants

9.2 Transparency Rule

The platform always makes explicit whether a poll or trend result is platform-internal, curated and interpretive, methodologically grounded, or merely indicative. **CIVITAS Public never simulates representativeness where none exists.**

10. Launch Modules

For immediate relevance and public visibility, CIVITAS Public launches with seven high-utility modules:

1. **Europe in Brief** — Short, clear, citable explanatory texts on current European topics.
2. **Trend Radar Europe** — Regular summaries of emerging questions and issue clusters.
3. **Debate Dossiers** — One issue, multiple perspectives, sources, tensions, and pathways forward.
4. **Citizen Questions** — Public questions answered by verified authors, editors, or experts.
5. **Policy Tracker** — Structured tracking of policy development: announced, negotiated, adopted, blocked, or implemented.
6. **Young CIVITAS** — Dedicated participation and learning area for schools, youth councils, students, and young European voices.
7. **CIVITAS Dialogues** — Moderated conversation formats with thematic boundaries and quality moderation.

11. Governance Framework

11.1 Core Governance Commitments

- No advertising revenue or commercial data exploitation
- Public, transparent rules for all platform operations
- Procedural fairness with documented moderation decisions
- Independent appeal mechanisms
- Regular transparency reports and external audits
- Democratic orientation with anti-capture safeguards

11.2 Governance Structure

Body	Responsibility
Foundation Carrier	Legal form, funding integrity, institutional continuity, strategic independence
Editorial and Standards Board	Publication rules, formats, review logic, quality standards

Body	Responsibility
Civic Oversight Panel	Fairness, intelligibility, legitimacy from citizen perspective
Ethics and Algorithm Review Group	Moderation systems, ranking logic, AI assistance, systemic risk
Appeals and Due Process Unit	Complaints, labelling disputes, access conflicts, moderation challenges

12. Technical Architecture

12.1 Design Principles

CIVITAS Public is built as a **modular, transparent, and interoperable system** — not a closed platform. Its technical design reflects democratic values: openness, auditability, sovereignty, and extensibility.

12.2 Technical Requirements

- Open-source codebase under permissive licensing
- European hosting with geo-redundant infrastructure
- Multilingual support with translation assistance
- Accessibility by design (WCAG 2.1 AA minimum)
- GDPR-compliant data handling with eIDAS identity integration
- Clear rights and roles management
- Exportable content with open formats
- Versioned publication logic with immutable audit trail
- Future federation capability (ActivityPub / Fediverse compatibility)

12.3 System Layers

Federation and API Layer (Interoperability, external integrations)
Moderation and Review Layer (Human moderation, AI support, appeals)
Resonance Layer (Polls, trends, interaction signals)
Identity and Role Layer (Registration, verification, permissions)
Publication Layer (Articles, briefs, dossiers, questions)

13. Legal Safeguards

Because CIVITAS Public structures political and civic visibility, rule-of-law safeguards are **foundational, not peripheral**.

Required elements include:

- Clearly defined publication and participation rules
- Visible content labelling and classification rules
- Documented moderation decisions with explanations
- Graduated enforcement logic (warning → restriction → removal)
- Independent complaint and appeal channels
- Anti-bot and anti-manipulation safeguards
- System overload and DDoS protection
- Privacy-by-design and security-by-default

Moderation principle: The objective is not maximum noise or maximum passivity, but **maximum democratic usability**. Moderation must be rule-bound, explainable, and reviewable.

13.1 Data Protection and GDPR Compliance

As a platform processing personal data of European citizens, CIVITAS Public must comply with the General Data Protection Regulation (EU) 2016/679 [14] from its earliest prototype stage. Key commitments:

Data categories and purpose limitation:

Data Category	Purpose	Legal Basis (GDPR)	Retention
Display name, profile	Public attribution of publications	Art. 6(1)(b) — contract performance	Account lifetime + 1 year
Identity verification data	Trust layer (eIDAS integration)	Art. 6(1)(b) + Art. 9(2)(g) — public interest	Verified status stored; source documents deleted after verification
E-mail address	Account management, notifications	Art. 6(1)(b)	Account lifetime
IP address, access logs	Security, anti-abuse	Art. 6(1)(f) — legitimate interest	90 days
Published content	Core platform function	Art. 6(1)(b)	Permanent (public archive)
Poll responses	Civic participation features	Art. 6(1)(a) — consent	Anonymised after aggregation

Privacy architecture:

- **Privacy by Design and by Default** (Art. 25 GDPR): Minimal data collection, pseudonymous participation for readers and registered participants, end-to-end encryption for private communications.
- **Right to pseudonymity:** Readers and registered participants interact under self-chosen display names. Only verified authors and certified publishers appear under attributable profiles — and even they may request pseudonymous publication with editorial justification.
- **Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA):** A formal DPIA (Art. 35 GDPR) is a **mandatory deliverable of Phase 0**, to be conducted before any personal data processing begins and published as an open-access document.
- **Data portability and deletion:** Users may export all personal data (Art. 20) and request deletion (Art. 17) at any time. Published content is retained in anonymised form for archival integrity.

- **Independent Data Protection Officer:** Appointed before public launch, reporting directly to the Foundation Carrier, not to the editorial or technical team.
- **Transparency reporting:** Biannual publication of data access requests, law enforcement inquiries, and moderation statistics.

13.2 Conflict of Interest Disclosure

The author of this paper is the initiator of the ERDA Initiative, within which CIVITAS Public is conceived. This structural interest is disclosed transparently. The governance framework (§11) is explicitly designed to prevent any single actor — including the initiator — from exercising undue control over platform operations, editorial decisions, or moderation policy.

14. Implementation Roadmap

Phase 0 — Concept and Coalition Building (Months 0-6)

- Finalise and publish this concept paper
- Establish founding coalition of civic-tech, institutional, and media partners
- Define role and verification scheme
- Prepare minimal website and public communications
- Secure initial funding and institutional support
- Conduct Data Protection Impact Assessment (DPIA) and publish results
- **Evaluation:** Stakeholder survey on concept acceptance; coalition commitment tracking (target: ≥ 5 institutional partners)

Phase 1 — Minimum Viable Platform (Months 6-18)

- Launch articles, briefs, and citizen questions
- Implement CIVITAS-ID system
- Deploy verified author profiles
- Enable simple polling
- Publish initial dossiers
- Publish foundational platform rules and standards
- Begin Europe in Brief and Trend Radar modules
- **Evaluation:** Usability testing with 50-100 beta users (SUS score target: ≥ 70); monthly active user tracking; biannual user trust survey (baseline measurement); publication volume and review level monitoring

Phase 2 — Trust and Depth Expansion (Months 18-36)

- Make review layers visible and operational
- Introduce trend reports and debate formats
- Launch Young CIVITAS and CIVITAS Dialogues
- Formalise and test appeal process
- Strengthen editorial and civic partnerships across EU member states
- **Evaluation:** Quantitative discourse analysis (NLP-based argument diversity and source density metrics [13]); cross-border readership analytics; comparative study vs. commercial platform discourse samples; first external evaluation report (open access)

Phase 3 — Institutional Extension (Months 36-60)

- Assess and implement DOI integration
- Build civic-tech interfaces for petitions and consultations
- Strengthen municipal and parliamentary connections

- Deepen multilingual operations across all EU languages
- Expand interoperability and federation logic
- **Evaluation:** Full KPI review against targets (\$2.6); independent academic evaluation; longitudinal trust measurement (pre/post comparison); institutional uptake tracking; publication of comprehensive evaluation report

15. Risk Assessment and Mitigation

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation
Perception of elitism due to verified-only publishing	Medium	High	Clear access pathways, open citizen questions, reviewed guest contributions, transparent participation architecture
Insufficient early momentum	High	High	Early deployment of high-utility formats (Europe in Brief, Trend Radar, Citizen Questions); partnerships with established media and civic organisations
Governance overload	Medium	Medium	Minimal but principled governance core; scale structures incrementally
Confusion with social media	Medium	Medium	Clear format logic, thematic structure, visible standards, deliberate distance from feed incentives
Political capture attempts	Low	Critical	Foundation independence, multi-stakeholder oversight, transparency reports, anti-capture design
Technical infrastructure costs	Medium	Medium	Open-source development, EU funding mechanisms, institutional co-financing

16. Strategic Value Proposition

For Citizens

Better orientation in complex political landscapes, more trustworthy information sources, structured participation opportunities, and reduced exposure to algorithmic manipulation.

For Media and Journalism

A visible, accountable space for quality civic publication beyond commercial platform logic, with improved European discoverability and durable archiving.

For Academia and Expert Communities

A public-facing publication channel connecting research with civic discourse, thematic dossier collaboration, and knowledge transfer into broader society.

For Youth and Education

Safer and more meaningful participation spaces, democratic learning through real public formats, and entry paths into European civic discourse.

For Institutions and Civil Society

Structured issue mapping, publicly visible civic questions, better continuity between debate and institutional follow-up, and stronger connections between citizens and their representatives.

17. Discussion

17.1 Limitations and Known Risks

Transparency about the limitations of CIVITAS Public is essential for its credibility. The following constraints and risks must be acknowledged:

Structural limitations:

- **Digital divide.** Access requires internet connectivity, digital literacy, and a compatible device. Citizens in rural areas, older demographics, and lower-income households may be systematically underrepresented unless active countermeasures (offline access points, simplified interfaces, accessibility investments) are implemented.
- **Verification barriers.** Identity verification, while essential for trust, may deter privacy-conscious citizens or those without compatible identification documents. The balance between security and inclusivity remains an open design challenge.
- **Language asymmetry.** Despite multilingual ambitions, early content will likely skew towards languages with more contributors (English, German, French). Smaller language communities risk marginalisation without dedicated editorial investment.
- **Echo chamber potential.** Even moderated platforms can develop ideological clustering. If self-selection dominates participation, CIVITAS may reproduce rather than bridge political divides.

Operational risks:

- **Insufficient adoption.** If fewer than 5,000 active users engage after 18 months, the platform may lack the critical mass necessary for democratic relevance. Contingency: pivot to a curated publication model with institutional partnerships before reassessing participatory features.

- **Financial sustainability.** After initial seed funding, the platform must secure ongoing financing without commercial revenue. Dependency on a single funder (e.g., one EU programme) creates fragility. Diversified funding (foundation grants, institutional subscriptions, public mandates) is essential but unproven.
- **Governance capture.** Despite anti-capture safeguards, well-organised interest groups could attempt to dominate editorial boards or oversight panels. Regular rotation, term limits, and external audits are necessary but not sufficient guarantees.
- **Content liability.** As a platform hosting user-generated content with editorial review, CIVITAS occupies an ambiguous position between publisher and intermediary under the Digital Services Act. Legal classification must be clarified early.

Methodological limitations of this paper:

- This paper presents a normative concept, not empirical results. Claims about expected effects (trust formation, discourse quality) are theoretically grounded but unvalidated.
- The author is the initiator of the ERDA Initiative, which creates an inherent interest in the project's success. Independent evaluation is therefore essential.
- Comparisons with existing platforms (§3.1) are based on publicly available documentation, not systematic empirical assessment.

17.2 Discussion Its value lies in its intermediary function: it occupies the currently underbuilt space between open discourse and trustworthy structure, between digital reach and democratic maturity, between public visibility and responsible continuity.

The initial restriction of publication rights to verified and certified actors is a practical mechanism for trust formation, not an end in itself. This restriction can only remain legitimate if accompanied by genuine civic accessibility, transparent review procedures, open input channels, and visible pathways for participatory expansion.

If successful, CIVITAS Public would not merely add another platform to Europe's digital landscape. It would help establish a **different public habit**: visibility with responsibility, discourse with memory, and civic participation with intelligible structure.

The feasibility of this vision rests not on technological novelty but on political will, institutional commitment, and civic engagement. The technologies required — content management systems, identity verification, multilingual support, moderation tools — are mature. What is missing is the **democratic determination to deploy them for public purposes**.

18. Call to Action

CIVITAS Public can begin today. It does not require constitutional amendments, new EU treaties, or breakthrough technologies. It requires **committed people and institutions willing to build democratic digital infrastructure**.

We invite:

- **Civic-technology developers and communities** to contribute to the open-source platform development, beginning with the publication and identity layers.
- **European institutions** — the European Parliament, European Commission, Committee of the Regions, and national parliaments — to recognise the democratic infrastructure gap and support CIVITAS Public through funding, institutional endorsement, and policy integration.
- **Media organisations and journalist networks** to participate as early certified publishers, contributing high-quality content and helping to establish editorial standards.

- **Universities and research institutions** to engage as knowledge partners, providing expert review capacity, hosting research on digital democracy, and connecting CIVITAS Public with emerging scholarship.
- **Civil society organisations** to bring their constituencies into the CIVITAS Public ecosystem, championing citizen participation and providing civic oversight.
- **Youth organisations, schools, and student networks** to help design and populate Young CIVITAS, ensuring that the next generation of European citizens shapes this space from the beginning.
- **Foundations and public funders** to provide the financial resources needed for an initial three-year development runway, structured as public-interest investment in democratic infrastructure.

The first concrete step is the formation of a **CIVITAS Founding Coalition** — a multi-stakeholder group committed to moving from concept to prototype within twelve months.

Contact: Interested parties are invited to reach out through the ERDA Initiative’s public channels or the repository associated with this paper.

19. Conclusion

Europe does not lack the technology to build a digital agora. It lacks the institutional commitment to try.

CIVITAS Public is conceived as a **realistic, visible, and strategically sound entry point** into a future European democratic digital infrastructure. It combines publication, debate, issue tracking, trend observation, and democratic trust architecture in a form that is both usable in the near term and expandable in the long term.

Its promise is not perfection, but a **credible beginning**.

Readable for all. Trustworthy through verification. Valuable through accountability.

Under the right institutional, editorial, and technical conditions, CIVITAS Public can become the first concrete building block of a European democratic civic infrastructure that is neither captured by advertising logic nor reduced to bureaucratic state communication.

The question is not whether Europe can build this. The question is whether it will.

We believe it should. We invite you to help build it.

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Appendix A: CIVITAS Declaration (German Original)

CIVITAS ist als digitale Agora Europas gedacht: ein demokratisch kontrollierter, bürger-naher und technologisch souveräner öffentlicher Raum, der nicht wie eine kommerzielle Social-Media-Plattform funktionieren soll, sondern als verlässliche Infrastruktur für Teilhabe, Meinungsfreiheit und demokratische Selbstwirksamkeit. Das Ziel ist, Bürgerbeteiligung zu stärken, politische Prozesse transparenter zu machen und demokratische Kultur langfristig zu fördern.

Getragen werden soll CIVITAS von einer unabhängigen europäischen Stiftung unter parlamentarischer Kontrolle, unter Einbindung von Zivilgesellschaft, Jugendräten, Medien und Wissenschaft. Bürgerbeteiligte Aufsicht, Ethikkomitees für algorithmische Entscheidungen, öffentliche Audits sowie der Verzicht auf Werbung und kommerzielle Datenverwertung sollen Vertrauen und demokratische Legitimation sichern.

Technisch ist CIVITAS als dezentrale, Open-Source- und Fediverse-kompatible Plattform vorgesehen, mit europäischem Hosting, DSGVO-, eIDAS- und EMRK-Konformität, Mehrsprachigkeit, Barrierefreiheit und transparenten Algorithmen ohne versteckte Rankings. Zu den Kernfunktionen gehören ein verifizierter Debattenraum mit KI- und menschlicher Moderation, Bürgeranträge, Schnittstellen zu Wahlen und Konsultationen, politische Informationsmodule wie Abstimmungstracker sowie Civic-Tech-Werkzeuge zur Mitgestaltung.

Zugleich setzt das Konzept auf Rechtssicherheit und Missbrauchsschutz: rechtsstaatliche Moderationsregeln, unabhängige Widerspruchsverfahren, Transparenzberichte, externe Audits und Schutz vor koordinierter Einflussnahme oder Überlastung. Ergänzt wird dies durch Partnerschaften mit Parlamenten, Kommunen, Bildungseinrichtungen, Medienhäusern und demokratischen Partnerstaaten sowie durch besondere Zugänge für Schulen, Hochschulen und Jugendräte. So versteht sich CIVITAS nicht nur als technisches Projekt, sondern als strategischer Pfeiler europäischer Demokratie.

Appendix B: CIVITAS Declaration (English Translation)

CIVITAS is envisioned as Europe's digital agora: a democratically governed, citizen-oriented and technologically sovereign public space. It is not meant to replicate a commercial social media platform, but to serve as a trustworthy civic infrastructure for participation, freedom of expression and democratic agency. Its purpose is to strengthen citizen involvement, make political processes more transparent, and foster democratic culture over the long term.

The platform is intended to be run by an independent European foundation under parliamentary oversight, with civil society organisations, youth councils, media and academia involved in its governance. Public-interest funding, citizen participation in oversight bodies, ethics committees for algorithmic decisions, and public audits are meant to ensure legitimacy, transparency and trust, while excluding advertising and commercial data exploitation.

From a technical perspective, CIVITAS is designed as a decentralised, open-source, fediverse-compatible platform, hosted in Europe and compliant with GDPR, eIDAS and the European Convention on Human Rights. It is meant to be multilingual, accessible, modular and transparent in its algorithmic logic, with no hidden rankings. Its core functions include a verified debate space moderated by both AI and humans, citizens' petitions, interfaces to elections and public consultations, political information modules such as voting trackers, and civic-tech tools for shaping public initiatives.

At the same time, the concept places strong emphasis on rule-of-law safeguards and resilience: clear moderation rules, independent appeal procedures, transparency reports, external audits, and protection against coordinated manipulation or system overload. CIVITAS is also intended to work with parliaments, municipalities, educational institutions, media organisations and

democratic partner countries, while offering safe participation channels for schools, universities and youth councils. In this sense, it is presented not merely as a technical platform, but as a strategic pillar of Europe's democratic future.

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